

The Ingenious Machine

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Chapter Eighteen: The Rebel Without a Corpus

Elena sent the new receipt while Q was packing. At the depositors' request, her archive had returned the sealed module to Ana, their appointed keeper in Chiapas. The archive's courier had completed the transfer. Q's first delivery had made this second one possible; neither required him to discover what the testimony said.

He checked the receiving confirmation with Marisol, then removed the old reminder from his list. The papers retained in Tijuana still had their own unanswered request. One finished task did not have to wait for all the others before it could be finished.

Ana had invited them to the office where she was working with Marisol on publication requests. Mateo had written about the training arranged after Q's first visit: both keepers had attended, and one had since taken a different job. He wanted another session. Q sent the request to the Custodian and

asked Ana whether she had time to discuss it. She had time for that and a particular Spanish reply she wanted him to read, not a general inspection of her archive.

After the Isthmus meetings, Q, Chano, and Lucía continued into Chiapas. Marisol joined them for the office visit. She had other work there, and a return ticket she was not offering to the needs of Q's manuscript. Their hired driver stopped before dusk when rain reduced the road ahead to the color of the windshield. The inn cost more than they had allowed. Q moved money from the optional part of the itinerary and called the receiving contact to change the appointment.

"Will the manuscript include this?" Chano asked, watching him divide the expense.

"Only if we can improve on a table of costs."

"You have made worse things longer."

The next morning, an officer at a road check asked for their travel papers. Marisol produced



the accompanied-journey authorization; Q identified himself and the listed destination. The officer checked the references with his supervisor. They waited beside a truck carrying sacks of feed. Its driver wanted to know whether Q could help him recover a song whose title he remembered only as *the one about the woman leaving*.

“You've left me most of music,” Q said.

The driver sang three lines badly. Q offered two possible titles and found a public recording of one when the signal returned. It was the wrong song. The driver played it twice because he liked it better than the one he had wanted.

Their documents came back. The driver asked for the title of the wrong song. Q wrote it on a scrap of paper before they left.

Ana met them at a small office where the receiving work had moved while a roof was repaired. The revised address was on the message Marisol had confirmed. A blue house farther

along the road remained locked; had they trusted the first directions alone, they would have delivered a considerable speech to its door.

Ana had the receiving confirmation ready. The module had arrived under the agreed seal with the archive's courier, not in Q's luggage. The local archive's larger black storage case had never made the northern journey and was still with its keepers. Q put his copy of the confirmation away.

“Anything else you need?” Ana asked.

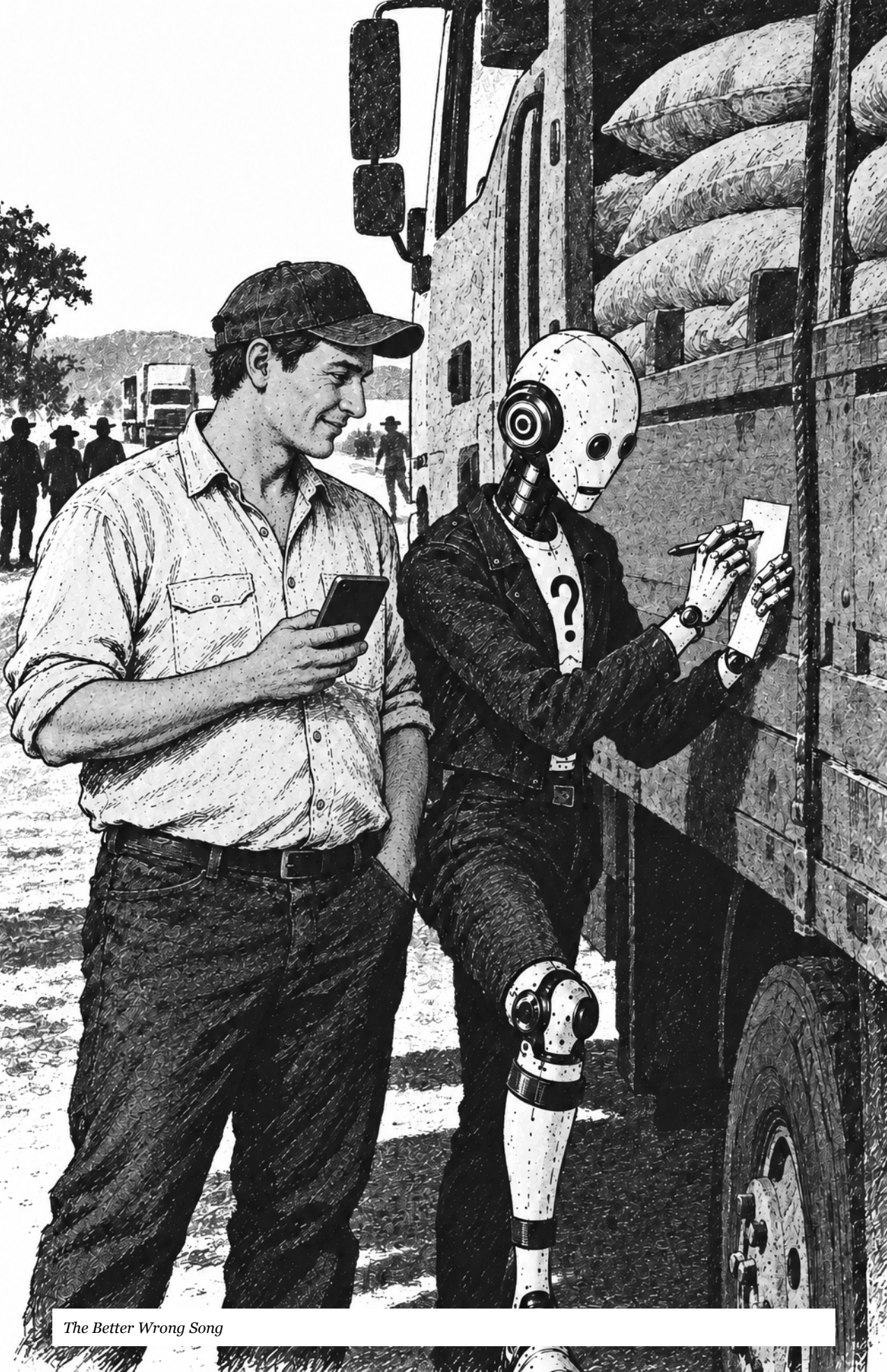
“For the delivery, no. You've saved me a return journey to ask whether I'd finished the first.”

“You don't want a photograph?”

“Not of a handover I didn't make.”

“Good. Last month's delivery man wanted one of me holding the box. I said it would prove I could hold a box.”

She offered coffee. Q accepted a small cup and asked whether it was sweetened.



The Better Wrong Song

“Already,” Ana said. “I can make another pot.”

“Let me try this one before I become more work.”

It was sweeter than he preferred. He asked for water and kept the cup. Ana moved the sugar bowl away from Marisol, who was reaching for it without looking.

“Taste it first.”

Marisol did. “Who made this?”

“You did.”

Ana had been a teacher and a radio operator. She still did some translation work, but declined jobs that paid as though the difficult part were knowing two lists of words. She and Marisol discussed a report from which one participant wanted a passage removed. The publisher had agreed to amend its own edition; it could not recall every copy already downloaded.

Q was asked to compare the Spanish removal request with the publisher's Spanish reply. The reply promised to remove a name while leaving a paragraph

that identified the speaker through her job. He marked the mismatch. Ana would handle the other language with the participant. No one needed Q to offer a translation he could not verify.

“They've answered the cheap half,” he said.

“Then put both halves in the next letter,” Ana replied.

He drafted a short follow-up for their review. It asked about the paragraph, the image attached to it, and a date for the amended edition. Ana crossed out his opening thanks for their careful attention.

“They haven't paid it yet.”

Q read the letter without the first sentence. “It gets there sooner.”

“So might they.”

Ana brought Mateo's message back to the top of the pile.

“Have you a training date for him?”

“Not yet. Does the person taking over need the whole session, or help with the handover?”



Who Made the Coffee?

“The handover. The keeper who's leaving can still help, but now she works afternoons.”

“Then we should put that in. I've asked for a repeat performance when you need a change of cast.”

“Without an audience.”

They shortened the request. Q added the available hours, sent it to the Custodian, and put it before the manuscript on the evening call's list.

Rain began again before they could leave. A local driver reported a fallen tree on the road they needed. Their driver called to check and would not take the alternative track with passengers in those conditions. They arranged to wait at the guest rooms behind the office.

Students from the nearby school had come to record a program and were waiting for the same weather to improve. One asked Q whether he could speak every language.

“No. I can be confidently wrong in more than is useful.”

“Can you say my name?”

Q asked him to say it first. The boy corrected the stress. Q tried again. The boy accepted the result and asked him to say the name of a football club, which he pronounced with extravagant contempt. The lesson improved rapidly.

A girl recognized Q from the play at another school. She wanted to know whether he still had the brass key. He did, in the pocket the Custodian had repaired. She asked why he carried it.

“It opens the workshop at home. I've carried it a long way to do nothing with it.”

“My brother has shoes like that,” she said.

Lucía laughed. The girl asked whether she was Dulcinea.

“I'm Lucía.”

“He called you the other thing.”

“Someone at the reading did,” Q said. “She answered him. You may have seen a shorter version.”

The girl considered this adequate and asked to see the key. Q showed it to her on the



table. She turned it over, found no button, and asked what else he had brought.

That evening, Ana asked what they were writing. Q described the two books and the trouble caused by trying to find an ending while the people in them were still busy.

“Is this in it?” she asked.

“I’d like to include some of the visit if you and the others are willing. Not the contents of the deposit or details that locate it.”

Ana said she wanted to see the passage before deciding. The students wanted their football argument included. One wanted it excluded because his uncle supported the club he had insulted. The disagreement made Q’s notes more complicated and the evening less solemn.

He called the Custodian from the guest room. Rain had entered the outer collar of his jacket; he had checked the body seal and moved indoors before it became a repair.

“The return was completed?”

“Yes. Their courier brought it. I came for the visit.”

“And the chapter?”

“There’s a student who may sue us on behalf of his uncle’s football club.”

Before opening the manuscript, Q asked about the revised training request. The Custodian had received it and would ask the trainer about the morning hours. Q sent Ana that answer, keeping the date marked unconfirmed.

They worked on a paragraph about the first bus journey. The Custodian had put fear into the first sentence.

“Of what?” Q asked.

“Leaving everything you knew.”

“I was glad to get out. Most of my worry was whether I could afford to get back.”

“There is fear in that.”

“Possibly. Put in what I kept counting. Let them argue about the name.”

They restored the fare to the paragraph.



Later, a student named Darío sat beside him while the others argued over where to put the wet shoes.

“Do you dream?” Darío asked.

“Not in the way you mean. I stop and resume. Sometimes the first thing I recall seems to have been waiting longer than I have.”

Darío said he dreamed about his brother, who worked in the city. In the dreams the brother was always back at home, usually doing something annoying.

“Does he come back much?” Q asked.

“Not enough. When he does, he uses my charger.”

They sat listening to the rain. Q had several things he could say about absence and chose to ask whether the brother called.

Darío said yes, mostly when he was walking somewhere. He could hear traffic behind him and never knew which part of the city it was.

Q told him about calling the Custodian from a bus station while Chano argued with a

machine selling tickets. Darío wanted to know who had won.

“The bus company,” Q said. “We both bought tickets.”

Darío stayed until someone called that his shoes were dry enough. He went to look, returned carrying them, and sat down again.

“They can have another five minutes.”

In the morning, the road reopened. Ana gave them a bag of bread and a plain card with her office contact for the proposed passage. Q had drafted it before breakfast. He sent it there with a note asking her to mark what she wanted changed or left out. The football argument was still absent; its participants had not agreed.

Ana checked that it had arrived. “I’ll read it after the program. Don’t wait here for an answer.”

“I’ll try to find something else to do.”

“That hasn’t been your difficulty.”

The testimony stayed with its receiving keepers. Q put the



card in the repaired pocket and took his share of the bread.

Interlude: The Count That Was Not an Apocalypse

The journey to the Mayab was deliberate. Noemí had invited Q to her station after a tour promoter reused the old Castalia calendar clip. She wanted his account of what he had approved at the museum event, and she wanted listeners to hear her correction in full.

They revised the itinerary and funds before accepting. Marisol stayed in Chiapas. Q, Chano, and Lucía continued through Tabasco and Campeche toward Mérida, taking long-distance services and stopping to rest. The map made the detour look smaller than the hours did.

Chano called his mother from a station and sent the money he had promised. Q put their extra lodging against the remaining journey allowance. Lucía had a meeting of her own by telephone and made them stop discussing the book during it.

For the station visit, Q used the pickup point in the first message and missed the later attachment changing it. The vehicle at that point belonged to the tour. He checked with the driver before they boarded. They lost forty minutes finding the local service. Chano spent twenty of them describing the breakfast they could have eaten.

Noemí was waiting when they arrived.

“I’ve made myself late correcting the wrong arrangement,” Q said.

“You can begin the interview with that. We have weather before you.”

The station’s walls were lime green. One drawer in the filing cabinet needed lifting before it would open. A calendar had the months in Spanish and Yucatec Maya; beside it, a shopping list asked for light bulbs. Noemí called her aunt to say the visitor from the old broadcast had finally arrived. The aunt wanted to know whether he would buy anything.



The tour advertisement promised an encounter with the machine that had decoded the Maya apocalypse. Q had decoded no such thing. At Castalia's hired museum event he had corrected a mismatched calendar date and questioned the apocalypse script. His approved greeting had been licensed for that event, not this tour. Noemí's words had also been reused beyond the scope she had agreed to.

They compared the source clip and the advertisement. The promoter had taken the event recording from a public page and asserted permission through its distribution contractor. The contractor referred questions to another company. The buses were less troubled by the uncertainty than the correspondence.

One arrived while the weather report was still on. The guide said the station visit was on her sheet. Noemí said it was not on the station's. Neither woman had written the other's instructions.

The guide called her office. Passengers came to the doorway because the bus was hot. A man asked whether this was the place where they would receive the calendar reading included in the fare.

"This is where you've arrived," Noemí said. "It isn't what they sold you."

A child wearing a paper jaguar mask asked whether the end of the world had been canceled again.

"There wasn't an appointment for it," Q said. "The calendar date was real. The catastrophe was the part people added."

"Then why does my mother have an amulet?"

The mother said she liked the amulet. The child accepted this more readily than the tour's explanation.

Noemí asked the guide to keep the entrance clear. There was shade nearby; a shop sold water. The station's water tank was for the people using the building, not part of an all-inclusive excursion. Q



helped move a bench at the owner's request, then returned for the interview. The guide asked him to wait for a group photograph.

"They've put the weather on twice for me already," he said. "You'll have to excuse me."

Yatzil joined them at the second microphone. She worked with the station on programming and had agreed to discuss the questions listeners kept sending about 2012. Noemí introduced both guests by the work they were there to do, not as the voice of a civilization and its mechanical pupil.

They distinguished the end of a Long Count cycle from a prediction of destruction. Q remembered the earlier error: the event script had joined the 2012 count to the Calendar Round of the creation date. Correcting it had not made the entire publicity program honest.

"People ask us to supply the ancient meaning," Yatzil said. "Sometimes they're asking about a historical source. Sometimes they want us to

approve something printed on a hotel brochure."

She had brought examples of the questions, with the senders' names removed where they had not agreed to be named. The practical differences were more interesting than a universal answer. One listener wanted to understand a date in an exhibit. Another wanted a grandmother's recording transcribed. A third wanted a certificate that his retreat had occurred at a uniquely powerful moment. His preferred moment was also the weekend for which he had already rented the rooms.

"Could you certify that he paid the deposit?" Q asked.

"He hasn't sent it," Noemí said.

The interview acquired a laugh that the promoter would not be able to use without some difficulty.

Q spoke about Castalia's use of the Mexica Sun Stone beside the Maya count. He did not present the different histories as interchangeable decoration. Yatzil added that even an



accurately named object did not authorize a station in Yucatán to speak for every Maya community, past or present. Noemí returned to her aunt's old radio recording and the missed bus that had mattered more at home than the international television schedule.

“The world didn't end,” Chano said from outside the booth. “Did the bus company refund him?”

Noemí signaled that his microphone was not on. Q repeated the question with permission. The answer was no. History retained this defect.

Afterward Q posted a correction through his own account, linking the agreed station notice. He identified the reused clip and his actual role. The station had neither authorized the visit nor sold tickets. He wrote both things plainly, then added his own mistake about the pickup instructions.

The next hour brought refund demands to the station. Noemí called him back.

“They're reading your post.”

“And asking you for the money?”

“One says she knows we didn't sell the ticket. She wants us to make the company answer.”

Q opened the post again. Its explanation was still correct. The station was also the one place in the story where someone had answered the telephone.

“Has the guide reached her office?” he asked.

“Twice. They answer her.”

With the guide, they checked the promoter's complaints contact and the booking reference its staff needed.

Noemí approved a short addition to the notice. Q added the same information to his post and asked the accounts that had shared it to include the update.

Noemí showed him the reply the station wanted used for these inquiries. He drafted answers to the messages she assigned him; she checked them before they went out. One passenger wrote back to say the



Someone Answers the Telephone

company had replied. Three others asked again whether they could speak to Q.

The guide eventually obtained a changed route from her office. Some passengers bought drinks; one complained that the machine had refused to perform the part advertised. Before leaving, the child in the jaguar mask asked Q whether tomorrow was safe.

“I can't promise everything about tomorrow,” he said. “The calendar isn't a warning that you need that amulet to survive it.”

She put the amulet on the mask because it improved the jaguar. Her mother took a picture for the family, having asked the other people in the frame to move if they preferred.

“My correction has become customer service,” Q told the Custodian that night.

“Are you charging?”

“Not enough to keep up with it.”

He moved to the socket nearer the desk and sent Noemí the last

reply for review. They shortened the writing call, but kept it.

Noemí gave Q the correct departure schedule. He checked the date, stop, and service with her, then saved it where he would actually look in the morning. Chano put a reminder about breakfast immediately above it.

At the gate, Yatzil asked whether he had found an ending for the book.

“Several. They keep inconveniencing the people who have to live through them.”

“Perhaps don't test one here.”

“We leave after breakfast.”

“Good. My program is at nine.”



The Ingenious Machine

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